ROUTLEDGE DIRECT | ANALYTICS TRACKING | OCTOBER 2025

Tracking plan

What the website should record, when it should record it, and how we know it is working

For the web team and whoever manages the tag setup. Written from an audit of the GA4 export for 1 October 2024 to 30 September 2025, and three years of orders and ad platform data. Every problem listed here was found in that data. Simulated data, not Taylor & Francis performance.

Why this plan exists

The FY2026 budget is built on three sources that have to agree: the order system, GA4 and the ad platforms. Auditing the data, most of the work of getting them to agree went into tracking and tagging problems rather than analysis, and most of them were found by setting one source against another. This plan says what the site should record, so the next problem is caught in a week rather than found a year later.

What the audit found

Problem	What the data shows	Where it is fixed
Purchases sent twice	517 orders reached GA4 twice, 324 in January and 193 in February 2025	Event rules, and fix 1
Two days with no tracking	Nothing recorded on 13 and 14 May 2025, about 30,000 events	Quality checks
Channel tags written several ways	16 sources and 10 mediums, 14 and 9 once lower cased; six Meta campaigns in two spellings	Campaign tagging, and fix 2
Paid orders with no campaign tag	775 paid orders over three years with no campaign	Campaign tagging
Affiliate tags that do not name the partner	Three partners never appear as a source, and one source is not a partner	Campaign tagging
Event times on a fixed schedule	Each event sits a fixed number of seconds into its session; the purchase is stamped before the order on 26,902 of 27,947 orders	Event rules
No step between checkout and purchase	Meta checkout to purchase 15.8 percent against 37.5 to 38.0 for everyone else, with no way to see the screen they leave on	Two new events
Refunds never reach the platforms	$182,857 refunded on paid orders over three years, still revenue to Google and Meta	The refund event
Staff test orders in GA4	42 staff test orders, 43 purchase events	Internal traffic filter

Events and parameters

Naming rules

Plain on purpose. Inconsistent names are the most common reason channel and event reporting falls apart.

Rule	Example
Event and parameter names in lower case with underscores	`add_to_cart`, never `AddToCart`
Currency as an ISO code	`USD`, `GBP`, `EUR`
Money as a number, never text with a symbol	`148.50`, not `$148.50`
Campaign tags in lower case, built to a fixed pattern	`rtl_nonbrand_us_alwayson`
Source and medium only from the agreed list	See campaign tagging

The events

The current export holds six events: `session_start`, `page_view`, `view_item`, `add_to_cart`, `begin_checkout` and `purchase`. Its parameters are `ga_session_id`, `page_location`, `item_id`, `value` (checkout and purchase only) and `transaction_id`, and the books ride on `view_item`, `add_to_cart` and `purchase` in an items list with id, name, price and quantity. The table sets out what each event should carry and marks what is missing today.

Event	Fires when	Parameters it should carry	In the export today
`session_start`	A visit begins	`ga_session_id`	Yes
`page_view`	Any page loads	`page_location`, `page_title`	Yes, without `page_title`
`view_item`	A book page loads	`items` with `item_id`, `item_name`, `price`, `item_variant` (print or ebook)	Yes, without the format
`add_to_cart`	Add to basket is clicked	`items`, `value`, `currency`	Yes, without value and currency
`begin_checkout`	The checkout page loads	`items`, `value`, `currency`	Yes, without items and currency
`add_shipping_info`	Delivery details are submitted	`value`, `currency`, `shipping_tier`	No, to add
`add_payment_info`	Payment details are submitted	`value`, `currency`, `payment_type`	No, to add
`purchase`	The order is confirmed	`transaction_id`, `value`, `currency`, `items`, `shipping`, `tax`	Yes, without currency, shipping and tax
`refund`	A refund is processed	`transaction_id`, `value`, `currency`	No, to add
`sign_up`	An account is created	`method`	No
`search`	A site search is run	`search_term`	No

The two checkout events

Between `begin_checkout` and `purchase` the export records nothing, and that is exactly where Meta traffic is lost. Meta visitors who reach checkout buy 15.8 percent of the time, against 37.6 percent for affiliate traffic, 38.0 for Google and 37.5 for owned and organic. For Meta Prospecting it is 14.8 percent on desktop, 11.4 on mobile and 13.0 on tablet.

It does not look like a tracking fault: GA4 sees 86.7 to 88.2 percent of Meta's orders on each device, much the same as the 87.5 to 88.7 percent for every other family. Nor does it look like the Facebook and Instagram in-app browser, because desktop is as far behind as mobile, and the gap is there in every month from October 2024. The orders look genuinely lost, and nobody can say at which step.

`add_shipping_info` fires when delivery details are submitted and `add_payment_info` when payment details are. With both in place the checkout splits into three steps, and the next look at Meta traffic can say whether people leave at delivery (a cost they did not expect) or at payment (an account to create, a card form, a method not offered). The question is then which fix to test, not where to look.

Event rules

- **The purchase event fires once per order, and only once.** It carries the order id from the order system in `transaction_id`, so every GA4 purchase can be matched to an order. Today that match works on every purchase: revenue, device and account agree with the order system.
- **Every event is stamped with the time it happens.** In the current export, events sit at fixed offsets from the session start (`begin_checkout` always 210 seconds in, `purchase` 260), so the export shows the order of events in a visit but not how long anything took. Time on site and time to checkout cannot be measured until this is fixed.
- **Staff and test traffic is filtered out.** Staff accounts on the internal test domain are marked as internal traffic and excluded from reporting views.
- **A browser id belongs to one browser.** 4,959 browser ids show two device types and 3,570 show two countries across their sessions. A single browser cannot change device type, and only rarely changes country. The web team should check how the id is set and kept before journeys are read across devices.

Campaign tagging and the two fixes

Allowed values

Every paid, email and affiliate link carries all three tags, written the same way every time, from this list.

Tag	Allowed values	Example
`utm_source`	google, facebook, klaviyo, newsletter, and each affiliate partner's id from the network	`google`
`utm_medium`	cpc, shopping, paid_social, email, affiliate	`cpc`
`utm_campaign`	The campaign name exactly as it appears in the ad account, in lower case	`rtl_nonbrand_us_alwayson`

Organic search, referral and direct are recorded by the site from the referring page and are not tagged by hand.

Four things in the current data break this list. Meta traffic arrives under four sources and two spellings of the medium. Google search arrives as google and Google, with cpc and CPC. One content partner, academic-reads, comes in with the medium referral on 1,365 orders, so grouping by medium would count it as referral traffic rather than affiliate. And the affiliate sources do not name partners: voucherhub, student-codes and phd-toolkit are partners in the network but never appear as a source, while coupons-site appears as a source but is not a partner. Until tagging is fixed, the clean layer maps every tag combination found so far (50 of them) to one of 13 channels, so any new spelling has to be added to that map by hand.

Fix 1: purchases sent twice

> **WHAT TO TELL THE DEVELOPER**
>
> The purchase event must reach GA4 once per order, whatever happens on the confirmation page. Send it from the server when the order system confirms the order, keyed on the order id, rather than from the browser when the confirmation page loads, so a reload, a back button or a second tag cannot send it again. If it has to stay in the browser, keep a record of order ids already sent and skip any id that is on it. If the same purchase is also sent to an ad platform from both browser and server, both copies carry the same event id so the platform counts one.
>
> Then watch for it: purchase events per order, every day. It should be 1.00. Above 1.02 on any day, someone looks the same day.

The export does not say what caused the January and February duplicates, only that 517 orders were sent twice and that the second events do not look like they reached the ad platforms. The fix above closes both of the usual causes, a page that fires twice and a second tag on the same page.

Fix 2: tags written several ways

HOW TAGS SHOULD BE PRODUCED

Nobody types a campaign tag. Each ad account builds its tags from a URL template set once at account level: the fixed source and medium from the list above, and the campaign tag taken from the campaign name, in lower case. Email links get their tags from the email platform's own settings, and affiliate links from the network, with the partner's id as the source.

New campaigns follow one naming pattern, brand, type, market and how it runs (for example `rtl_nonbrand_us_alwayson`), and the analyst adds each new campaign to the channel map before it launches. A weekly check lists any source, medium or campaign that is not on the list, and each one is fixed or mapped within the week.

This closes the spelling problem at the source, and the weekly check catches anything that gets through before it reaches a report. It also gives every paid order a campaign, which today 775 of them lack.

Consent, gaps and the checks that keep it honest

Consent

Visitors who decline tracking are not recorded, which is correct, and it is the usual reason GA4 shows fewer orders than the order system. In the past year GA4 missed between 10.5 and 12.1 percent of orders every month except May, when the two day outage took it to 17.2 percent. On paid orders over the 51 complete weeks of the year it saw 88.1 percent, with no real difference between Google (88.4) and Meta (87.6).

What matters is knowing the normal size of the gap, so that a change in it reads as an incident. Consent mode would let declined visits be counted in aggregate instead of disappearing. Until then, GA4 order counts are used for shares and rates, and the order system for totals.

The checks at the end of this section each carry a number, so whether one passes is not a matter of opinion, and the weekly ones belong in the weekly data health report. The platforms over-claim by a steady multiple (the ranges below are from the 48 ordinary weeks of the GA4 year), so the multiple is not the problem; a sudden move in it is.

Not implemented yet

Missing	Why it matters	Priority
`add_shipping_info` and `add_payment_info`	The Meta checkout loss cannot be located without them	High
`refund` event, passed to Google and Meta	The platforms count refunded orders as revenue: $182,857 on paid orders over three years	High
Real event times	Time to checkout and time on site cannot be measured	Medium
Consent mode	Declined visits disappear instead of being counted in aggregate	Medium
Partner id as the affiliate source	Commission cannot be checked partner by partner	Medium
`search` and `sign_up`	Site search and account creation are invisible	Low

Quality checks

Check	How often	Normal	What it catches
Days with no events	Daily	None	Outages like 13 and 14 May
Purchase events per order	Daily	1.00	Purchases sent twice
Orders GA4 sees, against the order system	Weekly	About 88 percent; 10.5 to 12.1 percent missing in a month	Tags failing, or a change in consent
Claims per order from each ad platform	Weekly	Google 1.229 to 1.235, Meta 1.215 to 1.227	A platform tag that broke or changed
New source, medium or campaign values	Weekly	None that are not on the list	Tags typed by hand
Paid orders with no campaign	Weekly	None	Links built without the template
Purchases with a value of zero	Weekly	None	Broken price or currency handling